TERRITORIAL WATERS



It's been thirsting to become a theme that gets enough airplay. And on October 16, Rajasthan's Eastern River Canal Project (ERCP) finally made the cut when Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and CM Ashok Gehlot landed in the barrenness of Baran district—part of a fist-like protrusion into the Madhya Pradesh map—to launch a poll yatra that will pass through all of 13 eastern Rajasthan districts. The key talking point: the Centre's tardiness in granting national status to the ERCP, which holds the promise of transforming the region. By contrast, the Gehlot regime's Rs 14,000 crore outlay for the project will be presented as keen-eyed munificence.

It was at a dull Jaipur conference on the Centre's Jal Jeevan Mission in April 2022 that the waters suddenly came to a boil, so to speak. State minister Mahesh Joshi demanded that PM Narendra Modi keep his promise of funding the project...and a cornered Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Union Jal Shakti minister, angrily denied the existence of any such promise! Shekhawat, from the western desert end of Rajasthan, has been a picture of discombobulation ever since: saying the project is technically unviable, and that the Centre's river-linking project would meet this zone's needs. And Gehlot, already sitting on a traditional edge in these parts for the Congress, has been milking the issue for all it's worth ever since.

LOYALTY POINTS



Dalit, Adivasi, the poor, youth, women...the order of wooing usually goes like that during poll season. But Congress veteran Digvijaya Singh has made a novel pitch: to IAS officers in Madhya Pradesh. Last week, he promised that state bureaucrats who'd been penalised by the Shivraj Singh Chouhan regime would get justice! Any adverse entries in their Annual Confidential Reports would be expunged if the Congress came to power. In power terms, think of it as a EBC sub-category within the ruling clique.

More Hindu Than Thou



Soft Hindutva? In 'Kamal' Nath's Madhya Pradesh, that barb at the Congress seems seriously old-fashioned—its devoutly observant aspect here could make a *jyotishi* blush. Its first list of candidates came on October 15, very consciously timed on the first day of Navratri, and a day after the inauspicious Shraadh/ Pitr Paksha period drew to a close. It was released at 9.09 am and had 144 names—1 + 4 + 4 = 9. Navratri, you see? It's all cloud nine.